

BROOKE VUCKOVIC AND REBECCA TALBOT

Moral Complexity in Leadership: Change and Conflict *Sweat*, by Lynn Nottage

About the Author

Lynn Nottage was born in 1964 in Brooklyn, New York. Her mother was a schoolteacher, principal, and activist, and her father was a child psychologist.¹ While in high school, Nottage wrote her first full-length play, which depicted a Black Shakespeare company's journey through the US South. After she earned a bachelor's degree from Brown University and a master of fine arts degree from the Yale School of Drama, she spent the next four years working as the press officer for Amnesty International, a position she viewed as a way to share people's untold stories.²

Nottage earned numerous awards for her plays, musicals, operas, screenplays, and other works. Her plays *Sweat* (2015) and *Ruined* (2008) each won a Pulitzer Prize, giving Nottage the distinction of being the first female playwright to win that award twice for drama. Her other awards include a MacArthur Fellowship (popularly known as the "genius grant"), a PEN/Laura Pels Master Dramatist Award, an American Academy of Arts and Letters Award, and a Guggenheim Grant. She was a professor of theatre at the Columbia School of the Arts and an artist-in-residence at the Park Avenue Armory.

Nottage is married to filmmaker Tony Gerber and has two children. Gerber and Nottage co-founded Market Road Films, co-wrote and will co-direct the feature film *Everlasting Yea!*,

and produced the Peabody Award–nominated 10-part podcast series *Deep South*, part of the *Unfinished* podcast.

Setting

Sweat is set in Reading (pronounced like the color: *Red-ing*), a small city in Berks County, Pennsylvania, about 60 miles (100 kilometers) northwest of Philadelphia. It is considered part of the “Rust Belt,” a region in the Northern US that experienced significant economic decline as factories and related businesses vanished in the late-20th and early-21st centuries. In 2011, Reading “earned the unwelcome distinction of having the largest share of its residents living in poverty,” according to *The New York Times*—a fact that prompted Nottage to set her play in the city.³

The play opens in 2008 and flashes back to 2000, a time when Reading was rapidly losing jobs; employment in the city dropped some 10 percent between 2000 and 2010, according to *The New York Times*.⁴ By 2011, the city’s poverty rate was 41.3 percent.⁵

When Nottage traveled to Reading and asked residents to describe their city, she noticed that they responded by saying, “Reading *was*” rather than “Reading *is*”—always looking back to the city’s prosperous past. This troubled her. “I thought a city that can’t imagine itself in present tense or future tense really is going to have a struggle with identity,” she said in an interview with the Oregon Shakespeare Festival.⁶ *Sweat* captures this ethos in its characters’ reflections on previous generations’ experiences in Reading and their inability to imagine their future, whether in Reading or elsewhere.⁷

Reading once “boasted 700 manufacturing businesses, producing hundreds of goods from hosiery to hardware,” according to Lindsay Lazarski in the public affairs newsletter *Then and Now*, but the city struggled after manufacturing declined.⁸ “In Berks County, once famous for the Reading Railroad stop on the Monopoly board game,” write Bob Davis and Gary Fields in *The Wall Street Journal*, “social ills have been exacerbated by a 30% decline in manufacturing jobs and 6% fall in inflation-adjusted median income since 1995.”⁹ In 2011, only 8% of Reading residents had a Bachelor’s degree (well below the 30% national average¹⁰), which underscores the significance of the industrial base to its residents’ economic security and upward mobility.¹¹

Reading a Play

“I write plays because I love the collaborative aspect of theater,” Nottage said in an interview. “A play begins with a solitary act, a few words and ideas typed across the computer screen. Those words then get interpreted by a director, by actors, by designers, and finally by an audience. It is then that it becomes something more complicated and layered; it becomes the voice of many artists.”¹²

Given this complex collaborative nature, plays can be challenging to read; in performance, the actors’ physicality carries the weight of characterization and clarifies relationships beyond what is contained in the dialogue. Trailers, photo galleries, and even a full-length version of the

play are listed under “Suggestions for Further Reading,” below, to aid in understanding the play’s visual elements.

Characters

Brief descriptions of the characters are included in the front matter of the play. A few notable relationships are highlighted below:

- Jason and Chris are longtime friends; both work at Olstead’s Steel Tubing Company
 - Jason is Tracey’s son; his father, Hank, is deceased
- Chris is the son of Cynthia and Brucie, who are separated; Brucie lost his job at a textile mill
- Jessie, Tracey, and Cynthia are longtime friends and coworkers at Olstead’s
- Stan is the bartender at Howard’s bar, which serves as the characters’ gathering spot. Before bartending, Stan was injured while working at Olstead’s
- Oscar works for Stan as a busboy

Several characters (Stan, Tracey, and Jason) are each described as “white American of German descent,” which captures the region’s Pennsylvania Dutch heritage.¹³ Pennsylvania Dutch—which many say is a transliteration of the German word “Deutsch,” or German—refers to immigrants who came to southeastern Pennsylvania before 1800 from what is now southwestern Germany. The region’s Pennsylvania Dutch heritage is a point of pride and drives tourism, mainly through historic sites and traditional foods.¹⁴

Several characters (Evan, Chris, Cynthia, and Brucie) are Black, born in Berks County. Reading’s Black history dates from its founding in the 1740s, when enslaved Africans were forced to live and work in the city.¹⁵ Pennsylvania passed an early abolition act, in 1780, but the emancipation of enslaved people was so gradual that two elderly Black women were still enslaved in Berks County as late as 1840.¹⁶ Reading was a site of Black resistance to slavery and racism. In the mid-nineteenth century, for instance, the Bethel African Methodist Episcopal Church was one of several Berks County way stations on the Underground Railroad* for enslaved people seeking freedom.¹⁷ Later, during the US civil rights movement of the 1960s, Reading’s Black leaders found innovative community solutions to advance equal rights despite facing backlash and personal cost.¹⁸ Revitalizing the city has been a key goal of Reading’s active network of Black civic and fraternal organizations and churches.¹⁹ Members of the city’s Black community are leaders throughout the city, including in its vibrant arts scene, local politics, and civil rights activism.²⁰

Through the character of Oscar, a Colombian-American born in Berks County, Nottage reveals the importance of Latin Americans in Reading, as well as some of the hostility this community

* The Underground Railroad was an organized network of secret routes and safe houses in the 19th-century US that helped enslaved Africans escape from Southern states to freedom in the North.

has faced.* In 2011, when Nottage began her research, *The New York Times* noted “a large influx of Hispanics over the past decade,” who “moved from New York and other large cities, drawn by cheaper rent and the promise of a better life.”²¹ Although the Times article and other reports often focused on poverty and low education levels among Reading’s Latin Americans, this community significantly contributed to and shaped Reading. In 2012, *The Guardian* reported that “Latino-owned businesses are the fastest-growing group in the city,” making up over a quarter of Reading’s businesses. “We are the backbone of this city,” community leader and former city councilman Angel Figueroa told *The Guardian*.²² By 2020, Reading’s Latin American population was the highest of any Pennsylvania municipality, making it a powerful political force in Berks County, as it is nationwide.²³

Themes

Building and Losing Trust

Sweat, which premiered in 2015, portrays the alienation, anger, and feeling of invisibility surging through middle- and working-class America that received increased attention after the 2016 US presidential elections. The play captures the loss of trust between organizations and workers and illuminates how trust can be built, especially as characters reflect on what made a difference for them in prior generations, when the Olsteads used to walk the factory floor and knew about the work their employees were performing.

Resisting Heroes and Villains

Mounting business and community pressures across generations, races, and ethnicities throughout the play strain relationships and individuals’ capacity for empathy. Conducting interviews among a cross-section of Reading residents, Nottage found that “everyone was hurting, [but] in isolation. I wanted to put those people into dialogue, so they all recognized that they shared this one central narrative.”²⁴

Nottage had long tracked how working-class poverty was reshaping the American narrative. This prompted her journey to Reading and her depiction of what she calls the “de-industrial revolution,” which led to the erosion of the middle class.²⁵ She later reflected, “Everyone is complicit in the undoing of the country. There are no heroes, and there are no villains.”²⁶

* Like Oscar, Berks County’s Latin American community as a whole has faced discrimination; for instance, a 2003 lawsuit by the United States Justice Department cited “overt hostility” and discrimination against Hispanic voters by Berks County officials. (“Justice Department Files Lawsuit Against Berks County Election Regarding Alleged Violations of the Voting Rights Act,” February 25, 2003, United States Department of Justice, https://www.justice.gov/archive/opa/pr/2003/February/03_crt_115.htm.)

Balancing Perspectives

Leaders can easily see themselves, rather than their workers, as the true sacrificial heroes, yet *Sweat* vindicates the sacrifices of the working class and the dignity of their labor. Michelle Wilson, who played Cynthia on Broadway, reflected that “[recently] there seems to be a resentment towards working...there’s something about the working class and the dignity of labor—of getting up and taking care of your family; we [now] have a disconnect; the easier your money comes, the more worthy you must be—you know, you’re not a ‘sucker.’ And these people are not suckers. They’re hard workers who are doing everything they’re supposed to do to achieve the American dream.”²⁷

Sweat offers a scorching look at how leaders make and communicate their decisions and how much their employees’ sweat (and lives) matter to those who hold power. In Nottage’s play, the voices of “management” are silent, highlighting their lack of engagement with those who have served their organizations for decades.

Frequently Asked Questions

What is NAFTA?

In the play, Stan blames the North American Free Trade Agreement (NAFTA) for the decline of American manufacturing: “You could wake up tomorrow and all your jobs are in Mexico, whatever, it’s this NAFTA bullshit.” From 1994 to 2020, this trade pact gradually removed trade barriers between the US, Mexico, and Canada, allowing companies to ship goods without tariffs. Like Stan, critics of the trade deal say that, under NAFTA, competition from Mexican firms pushed US firms to move to Mexico.²⁸ However, according to *The Wall Street Journal*, “most economists say its concrete impact on the US economy has been modest—a small gain in growth and efficiency, and a small loss in jobs and lower wages for certain factory workers.” The perception in the US varies widely because “the gains over 23 years have been diffuse and the pains more concentrated.”²⁹

How does parole work?

Parole (also called provisional release or supervised release) is a form of early release offered to some imprisoned people based on the assessment of a parole board. A board offers parole based on factors such as good conduct and participation in rehabilitation programs while in prison, the availability of a permanent residence, and an offer of immediate employment upon release. Once released, a person on parole is considered to be still serving their sentence and is required to abide by behavioral conditions, including meeting regularly with a designated parole officer. This is Evan’s job in *Sweat*. The parole officer assesses the paroled person’s behavior and compliance with their other terms of release, which might include a curfew, avoiding drug or alcohol use, and not possessing a gun. If deemed as failing to meet any of the conditions, a paroled person can be rearrested and returned to prison to serve the remainder of their sentence.

What is the box Chris says he is “hitting up against”?

In Act 1, Scene 1, when Chris describes his efforts to find a job, he tells Evan, “And I keep hitting up against that box. That damn question’s a barbed wire fence, can’t go over it, can’t get around it.” The box refers to a checkbox commonly included on job application forms requiring applicants to disclose if they have ever been convicted of a crime. Checking “yes” reduced Chris’s chances of getting hired.



What is the Aryan Brotherhood, which Chris references?

The Aryan Brotherhood, which Chris references when speaking to Evan is a violent white supremacist neo-Nazi gang in the US. It was founded in 1964, largely by Irish bikers, in the San Quentin State Prison in California after prisons were desegregated, and people of different races began to be detained together.³⁰ Aryan Brotherhood members often have prominent, recognizable tattoos—sometimes on their faces—declaring their affiliation. These are Jason’s white supremacist tattoos mentioned at the start of the play.

Of Note

Sweat was awarded the 2017 Pulitzer Prize for drama. In addition, it was Nottage’s Broadway debut and was nominated for three Tony awards.

The reception of *Sweat* in Reading and other economically depressed cities was noteworthy. In 2017, *Sweat*’s Broadway theatre company traveled to Reading to perform the play, which was followed by an opportunity for audience members to share their stories. “It was almost like church,” says Nottage. “People stood up and wanted to share their own experiences.”³¹

Similarly, in 2018, the New York Public Theatre’s Mobile Unit took *Sweat* to eighteen Rust Belt and Upper Midwestern small towns and cities. Combating the perception that theatre had abandoned these regions just as the economy had, the ensemble performed for free in “union halls, churches, food pantries,” and “centers for men and women recently released from prison.” Like many others, an audience member from Aliquippa, PA, cried during the post-show discussion, noting that his story had just been made visible.³²

Sweat is not the only one of Nottage’s creative works set in and around Reading. In 2017, she wrote and co-created the multimedia performance art piece *This is Reading* with her husband, Tony Gerber, and Kate Whoriskey, the Broadway director of *Sweat*. Additionally, Nottage’s Tony-award nominated play, *Clyde’s* (2021), is set in Berks County. *Clyde’s* focuses on formerly incarcerated kitchen workers. Jason, a character in *Sweat*, also appears in *Clyde’s*.

Suggestions for Further Reading and Viewing

- Steven Bognar and Julia Reichert, *American Factory* (2019)

This documentary follows the reopening of a new factory, Fuyao Glass America, owned by a Chinese billionaire, at the former site of a Dayton, Ohio, General Motors plant. Although the reopening initially is celebrated as a historic moment, cultural and labor tensions soon escalate, and workers weigh the pros and cons of unionizing the factory.

- Lina Deng, Kimberly Scott, Cynthia Wang, and Jiangyong Lu, “The Fuyao Glass Cauldron: Creating the Third Leg of Success,” Northwestern University’s Kellogg School of Management case #KE1237.

This management case study asks students to address the challenges faced by Fuyao Glass America (FGA) in the aftermath of the events depicted in *American Factory*. FGA’s leadership must create an inclusive, engaging workplace that bridges cultural differences, overcomes the talent management challenges revealed during the unionizing effort by the United Auto Workers, and attract and retain skilled workers.

- Lorraine Hansberry, *A Raisin in the Sun* (1959)

Nottage recalled that she had been given her first copy of the award-winning play when she was 12, and “thereafter I would receive a copy ... as a gift about every three or four years. I guess God was trying to send a message to me. I remain in awe of the impact—social, cultural, and political—that it has had on the theatre. I aspire to create something as indelible and human as that play. It is the creative high bar.”³³

- Mo Yan, “Shifu, You’ll Do Anything for a Laugh” (2001)

In this short story by the Nobel Prize-winning Chinese author, Ding Shikou, known as “Shifu” (a respectful form of address for skilled workers), is abruptly laid off from his factory job just shy of retirement. When he can find no other way to support himself, he starts a secretive business that leaves him morally troubled.

- Market Road Films, *This is Reading* (2008)

An award-winning team of artists, including Lynn Nottage and filmmaker Tony Gerber, produced this dynamic multimedia installation that celebrates the city. *This Is Reading’s* use of current and archival footage of the city, its oral histories and interviews, and its setting in the historic Franklin Street Railroad Station in Downtown Reading might especially be of interest after reading or viewing *Sweat*.

- The following resources might be useful for visualizing the staged version of *Sweat*:
 - Trailer for the Oregon Shakespeare Festival’s production of *Sweat*: <https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=EB3iiUBX8jI>

- Photo gallery from the Broadway production of *Sweat*: <https://www.broadway.com/photos/gallery/74/show-photos-sweat/85310/>
- Interview with Nottage, which includes scenes from the play, from CBS Mornings: <https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=jGdHwJzR8X8>
- A local production of *Sweat* from Villager's Theater in Somerset, NJ: <https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=lBZybMFADgs>

Endnotes

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